Charcuterie Lab

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The Cured Meat Chart

100 cured meats in 8 families: how each one tastes, how strong it is, what to serve with it and which ones to cook first.

THE 8 FAMILIES AT A GLANCE

All cured meat starts with salt. Then it is either cooked (deli meats) or dried, as a whole cut (prosciutto) or chopped into a sausage (salami). The drier and older it is, the stronger it tastes.

FAMILY	TASTES	AGED	STRENGTH	FAMOUS EXAMPLES
1 **Cooked & smoked cold cuts**	Mild, juicy, a little sweet	None: cooked in hours or days	Mild to intense	Ham · Mortadella · Pastrami · Smoked turkey
2 **Semi-dry & snack sausages**	Tangy, smoky, chewy	Days to a few weeks	Gentle to bold	Summer sausage · Meat sticks · Landjäger
3 **Whole-muscle cured meats**	Silky, sweet-salty, nutty	A few months to 3+ years	Gentle to bold	Prosciutto · Jamón · Coppa · Bresaola
4 **Dry-cured salami & sausages**	Tangy, garlicky, often spiced	3 weeks to 6+ months	Gentle to bold	Genoa · Soppressata · Chorizo · Pepperoni
5 **Jerky & dried meats**	Chewy, concentrated, seasoned	Hours to a few weeks	Medium to bold	Beef jerky · Biltong · Droëwors
6 **Cured fat & belly**	Rich, melting, peppery	A few weeks to a few months	Gentle to bold	Lardo · Pancetta · Guanciale · Bacon
7 **Pâtés, rillettes & spreads**	Rich, smooth or rustic	Most are cooked; 'nduja and sobrasada are cured	Gentle to intense	Pâté · Rillettes · Liverwurst · 'Nduja
8 **Cured, smoked & tinned fish**	Briny, smoky, savory	Days (gravlax) to months (bottarga)	Mild to intense	Smoked salmon · Anchovies · Sardines · Caviar

Strength: Mild · Gentle · Medium · Bold · Intense

IF YOU LIKE THIS, TRY THAT (EASY TO BOLD)

Ham	Prosciutto cotto	Prosciutto di Parma	Jamón serrano	Jamón ibérico
Salami	Genoa	Finocchiona	Soppressata	Wild boar salami
Spicy	Pepperoni	Chorizo	Calabrese	'Nduja
Beef	Bresaola	Bündnerfleisch	Biltong	Pastirma
Smoky	Smoked turkey	Black Forest ham	Speck	Cecina
From the sea	Smoked salmon	Gravlax	Anchovies	Bottarga

GOOD TO KNOW

Building a board?
Pick one meat from three families: a whole-muscle meat (prosciutto), a salami (soppressata) and a spread (pâté). Plan 2 oz of meat per guest with a meal, 3 to 4 oz when the board is the meal.

Serving
Take prosciutto and salami out of the fridge about 20 minutes early so the fat softens. Fold slices loosely so they don't stick. Peel salami casings first.

Cook first
Pancetta, guanciale, bacon, lap cheong, sucuk, tasso and country ham are cured but meant to be cooked. The label will say "cook before eating".

Pregnant?
The CDC advises heating deli meats to 165°F, or until steaming hot, if you are pregnant, 65 or older, or have a weakened immune system. Baked on a pizza is fine.

All 100 cured meats (1 of 2)

Families 1–3: cooked cold cuts, semi-dry sausages and whole-muscle meats. Tick the ones you've tried.

MEAT	ANIMAL · FROM	STRENGTH	TASTES LIKE	TRY WITH	TRIED
1 Cooked & smoked cold cuts 14 types					
Prosciutto Cotto	Pork · Italy	●○○○○	Mild, juicy, lightly herbed ham	Fontina and focaccia	☐
Honey Ham	Pork · USA	●○○○○	Sweet, soft, gently smoky	Swiss cheese and mustard	☐
Jambon de Paris	Pork · France	●○○○○	Clean, mild, tender	Butter and baguette	☐
Smoked Turkey	Turkey · USA	●○○○○	Lean, light, lightly smoky	Cranberry and Brie	☐
Bologna	Pork & beef · USA	●○○○○	Mild, smooth, a little sweet	Yellow mustard and crackers	☐
Mortadella	Pork · Italy	●●○○○	Silky, mild, pistachio-flecked	Pistachios and Lambrusco	☐
Corned Beef	Beef · USA & Ireland	●●●○○	Salty, beefy, warm spices	Rye and grainy mustard	☐
Pastrami	Beef · USA	●●●●○	Peppery crust, smoky, rich	Rye and spicy mustard	☐
Montreal Smoked Meat	Beef · Canada	●●●●○	Smoky, peppery, less sweet than pastrami	Mustard and dill pickles	☐
Kielbasa	Pork · Poland	●●●○○	Garlicky, smoky, juicy	Sauerkraut and mustard	☐
Andouille	Pork · USA (Louisiana)	●●●●○	Smoky, peppery, coarse	Creole mustard	☐
Head Cheese	Pork · USA & Europe	●●●○○	Savory, herby, set in its own jelly	Vinegar and onions	☐
Morcilla	Pork · Spain	●●●●○	Rich, earthy, warm spices	Roasted peppers	☐
Tasso Ham COOK FIRST	Pork · USA (Louisiana)	●●●●●	Fiery, smoky, very seasoned	Beans, greens and gumbo	☐
2 Semi-dry & snack sausages 7 types					
Summer Sausage	Beef or pork & beef · USA	●●○○○	Tangy, smoky, mild	Cheddar and crackers	☐
Meat Sticks	Beef or pork & beef · USA	●●○○○	Smoky, salty, snappy	Pepper Jack cubes	☐
Kabanos	Pork · Poland	●●○○○	Smoky, thin, snappy	Pickles and beer	☐
Thuringer	Pork & beef · USA (German-style)	●●●○○	Tangy, smoky, peppery	Swiss and rye	☐
Landjäger	Beef & pork · Germany, Switzerland & Austria	●●●○○	Smoky, dense, lightly spiced	Gruyère and pretzels	☐
Lebanon Bologna	Beef · USA (Pennsylvania)	●●●●○	Sweet-sour tang, heavy smoke	Cream cheese roll-ups	☐
Lap Cheong COOK FIRST	Pork · China	●●●○○	Sweet, rich, rose-wine scented	Fried rice and scallions	☐
3 Whole-muscle cured meats 22 types					
Prosciutto di Parma	Pork · Italy	●●○○○	Sweet, silky, delicately salty	Melon or Parmigiano	☐
Prosciutto di San Daniele	Pork · Italy	●●○○○	Sweeter and softer than Parma	Fresh figs	☐
Prosciutto Toscano	Pork · Italy	●●●○○	Saltier, with pepper and herbs	Pecorino and Chianti	☐
Culatello	Pork · Italy	●●●○○	Deep, sweet, almost winey	Parmigiano and Lambrusco	☐
Lonzino	Pork · Italy	●●○○○	Lean, delicate, fennel and pepper	Pears and pecorino	☐
Coppa (Capicola)	Pork · Italy	●●●○○	Rich, marbled, warmly spiced	Aged provolone	☐
Speck	Pork · Italy (Alto Adige)	●●●○○	Smoky, juniper, lightly spiced	Apples and rye crackers	☐
Bresaola	Beef · Italy	●●○○○	Lean, sweet, deep red	Arugula, lemon and Parmigiano	☐
Jamón Serrano	Pork · Spain	●●●○○	Firmer and saltier than prosciutto	Manchego	☐
Jamón Ibérico	Pork · Spain	●●●●○	Nutty, rich, melting fat	Fino sherry	☐
Lomo	Pork · Spain	●●○○○	Lean, tender, paprika edge	Manchego and almonds	☐
Cecina	Beef · Spain	●●●○○	Smoky, beefy, deep	Olive oil and almonds	☐
Jambon de Bayonne	Pork · France	●●●○○	Mellow, lightly sweet, hint of chile	Sheep's milk cheese and cherry jam	☐
Duck Prosciutto	Duck · France & USA	●●●○○	Rich, gamey, buttery fat cap	Cherries or orange	☐
Presunto	Pork · Portugal	●●●○○	Savory, salty, deep red	Melon and vinho verde	☐
Pršut	Pork · Croatia & Slovenia	●●●○○	Dry, salty, sometimes smoked	Sheep's milk cheese and olives	☐
Westphalian Ham	Pork · Germany	●●●○○	Smoky, firm, salty	Rye bread and mustard	☐
Black Forest Ham	Pork · Germany	●●○○○	Smoky and sweet	Swiss cheese	☐
Bündnerfleisch	Beef · Switzerland	●●●○○	Lean, concentrated, alpine herbs	Gruyère	☐
Pastirma	Beef · Turkey & Armenia	●●●●○	Garlicky fenugreek crust, intense	Eggs or white cheese	☐
Country Ham COOK FIRST	Pork · USA (South)	●●●●○	Very salty, funky, intense	Biscuits and pepper jelly	☐
Jinhua Ham COOK FIRST	Pork · China	●●●●○	Intensely savory, used like a seasoning	Soups and braises	☐

All 100 cured meats (2 of 2)

Families 4–8: salami, jerky, cured fat, pâtés and spreads, and cured fish.

MEAT	ANIMAL · FROM	STRENGTH	TASTES LIKE	TRY WITH	TRIED
4 Dry-cured salami & sausages 18 types					
Genoa Salami	Pork · Italy (US-style)	●●○○○	Mild, garlicky, a touch of wine	Provolone	☐
Hard Salami	Pork & beef · USA	●●○○○	Firm, smoky, mild	Cheddar	☐
Milano Salami	Pork · Italy	●●○○○	Fine-grained, mild, garlicky	Grissini	☐
Salame Felino	Pork · Italy	●●○○○	Sweet, pure pork, peppercorns	Parmigiano	☐
Cacciatorini	Pork · Italy	●●○○○	Small, mild, garlicky	Olives and Asiago	☐
Finocchiona	Pork · Italy (Tuscany)	●●●○○	Fennel, soft, aromatic	Pecorino and Chianti	☐
Soppressata	Pork · Italy	●●●○○	Coarse, rustic, sweet or hot	Provolone and peppers	☐
Calabrese Salami	Pork · Italy (Calabria)	●●●●○	Hot chile, smoky red pepper	Honey and ricotta	☐
Wild Boar Salami	Wild boar & pork · Italy	●●●●○	Gamey, dark, rich	Pecorino and red wine	☐
Rosette de Lyon	Pork · France	●●○○○	Mild, buttery, coarse	Cornichons and Beaujolais	☐
Saucisson Sec	Pork · France	●●●○○	Garlicky, peppery, nutty	Comté and baguette	☐
Fuet	Pork · Spain (Catalonia)	●●○○○	Thin, mild, peppery	Manchego and cava	☐
Salchichón	Pork · Spain	●●●○○	Black pepper, nutmeg, savory	Marcona almonds	☐
Chorizo (Spanish)	Pork · Spain	●●●●○	Smoky paprika, garlicky	Manchego and olives	☐
Pepperoni	Pork & beef · USA	●●●○○	Smoky, spicy, paprika	Pizza, mozzarella	☐
Hungarian Salami	Pork · Hungary	●●●○○	Smoky, fine, white mold coat	Pickled peppers	☐
Kulen	Pork · Croatia & Serbia	●●●●○	Fiery paprika, garlic, smoke	Fresh cheese and bread	☐
Sucuk COOK FIRST	Beef · Turkey	●●●●○	Garlic, cumin, red pepper	Fried eggs	☐
5 Jerky & dried meats 6 types					
Beef Jerky	Beef · USA	●●●○○	Chewy, smoky, sweet-salty	Sharp cheddar	☐
Venison Jerky	Venison · USA	●●●○○	Lean, gamey, peppery	Blackberry jam and cheddar	☐
Biltong	Beef · South Africa	●●●●○	Beefy, coriander, vinegar	Chutney and red wine	☐
Droëwors	Beef · South Africa	●●●●○	Coriander, clove, chewy	Lager	☐
Bakkwa	Pork · Singapore & Malaysia	●●●○○	Sweet, sticky, grilled	Cold beer or jasmine tea	☐
Kilishi	Beef · Nigeria & Niger	●●●●○	Peanut-spice crust, crisp, hot	Plantain chips	☐
6 Cured fat & belly 6 types					
Lardo	Pork fat · Italy	●●○○○	Buttery, herby, melts on the tongue	Warm toast and honey	☐
Salo	Pork fat · Ukraine & Russia	●●○○○	Garlicky, rich, clean	Rye bread and pickles	☐
Pancetta COOK FIRST	Pork belly · Italy	●●●○○	Rich, peppery, porky	Pasta, peas and onions	☐
Bacon COOK FIRST	Pork belly · USA & UK	●●●○○	Smoky, salty, sweet	Dates and maple	☐
Guanciale COOK FIRST	Pork cheek · Italy (Rome)	●●●●○	Intensely porky, peppery, rich	Carbonara and pecorino	☐
Lap Yuk (Chinese Bacon) COOK FIRST	Pork belly · China	●●●●○	Sweet, soy, rice wine	Steamed rice	☐
7 Pâtés, rillettes & spreads 10 types					
Rillettes	Pork or duck · France	●●○○○	Rich, shreddy, slow-cooked	Cornichons and baguette	☐
Teewurst	Pork · Germany	●●○○○	Smoky, soft, mild	Rye toast	☐
Pâté de Campagne	Pork · France	●●●○○	Coarse, peppery, rustic	Dijon and cornichons	☐
Chicken Liver Pâté	Chicken · France	●●●○○	Smooth, rich, minerally	Fig jam and toast	☐
Foie Gras	Duck or goose · France	●●●○○	Buttery, very rich, sweet	Sauternes and brioche	☐
Pâté en Croûte	Pork & game · France	●●●○○	Savory, layered, in pastry	Mustard and pickles	☐
Liverwurst	Pork · Germany	●●●○○	Smooth, livery, savory	Rye and red onion	☐
Braunschweiger	Pork · USA (German-style)	●●●○○	Smoked, livery, creamy	Crackers and onion	☐
Sobrasada	Pork · Spain (Mallorca)	●●●●○	Paprika, soft, sweet heat	Honey on toast	☐
'Nduja	Pork · Italy (Calabria)	●●●●●	Fiery chile, spreadable, funky	Burrata and toast	☐
8 Cured, smoked & tinned fish 17 types					
Cocktail Shrimp	Shrimp · USA	●○○○○	Sweet, clean, firm	Cocktail sauce and lemon	☐
Smoked Trout	Trout · USA & Europe	●●○○○	Flaky, mild smoke	Horseradish cream	☐
Smoked Salmon	Salmon · Scotland, Norway & USA	●●○○○	Silky, smoky, rich	Cream cheese and capers	☐
Gravlax	Salmon · Sweden & Norway	●●○○○	Dill, sweet, silky, not smoked	Mustard-dill sauce	☐
Lox	Salmon · USA (Jewish deli)	●●●○○	Salty, silky, not smoked	Bagels and cream cheese	☐
Ventresca (Tuna Belly)	Tuna · Spain & Italy	●●○○○	Buttery, tender, in olive oil	Piquillo peppers	☐
Tinned Mackerel	Mackerel · Portugal & Spain	●●●○○	Rich, meaty, oily	Lemon and crusty bread	☐
Sardines	Sardine · Portugal & Spain	●●●○○	Rich, savory, briny	Lemon and toast	☐
Tinned Octopus	Octopus · Spain & Portugal	●●●○○	Tender, briny, smoky paprika	Potato chips and vermouth	☐
Smoked Oysters	Oyster · USA & Asia	●●●○○	Smoky, briny, soft	Saltines and hot sauce	☐
Pickled Herring	Herring · Scandinavia & Netherlands	●●●○○	Sweet-sour, briny, firm	Rye, onion and aquavit	☐
Boquerones	Anchovy · Spain	●●○○○	Bright, vinegary, mild	Olives and cava	☐
Anchovies	Anchovy · Spain & Italy	●●●●●	Very salty, deeply savory	Butter and radishes	☐
Mojama	Tuna · Spain	●●●●○	Dense, salty, like tuna prosciutto	Almonds and olive oil	☐
Bottarga	Mullet or tuna roe · Italy	●●●●●	Salty, briny, intensely savory	Shaved over pasta	☐
Ikura (Salmon Roe)	Salmon roe · Japan & Russia	●●●○○	Juicy pops, briny, rich	Blini and crème fraîche	☐
Caviar	Sturgeon roe · Caspian region & farms	●●●●○	Briny, buttery, delicate pop	Blini and Champagne	☐